

Europe's scramble for energy

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in.

In today's Playbook:

- The EU is mulling plans to reform — or even scrap — its EPSO exam board.
- A peek at how Brussels is trying to help rural people stay where they live.
- Faces in the crowd: Dan Jørgensen, Donald Trump, Mark Rutte, Dorin Junghietu, Marta Kos, Sarah Matthieu, Nigel Farage, Kata Tűttő, Raffaele Fitto, Marco Rubio and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian unpack why rising energy prices send mainstream politicians clambering to fend off the far right.

**A message from Amazon: 60% of sales on Amazon come from independent sellers like Lucas from Novoma in Toulouse, France. Founded to make well-being accessible, Novoma now reaches customers across Europe with Amazon—growing beyond its home market while staying rooted locally. Learn how Amazon helps European small businesses grow. **

DRIVING THE DAY

EUROPE'S WINTER ENERGY SCRAMBLE: EU energy czar Dan Jørgensen is leading urgent talks in Ireland today on how the bloc can secure its energy supply and ward off a winter crisis, three diplomats and officials told Playbook.

The EU is pushing to diversify energy sources as Donald Trump threatens to cut off diesel exports to Europe, wars in Ukraine and the Middle East drive up prices and Russian hybrid attacks unsettle suppliers. Ministers from the U.K., Ukraine and Norway are among those attending talks on possible energy partnerships, Ben Munster reports from Dublin.

The bloc's battle with high energy prices has been raging for months, but the alarm level ratcheted up over the weekend as Jørgensen sent a letter to EU capitals urging them to consider energy savings similar to measures put in place after Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

EU gas stores are running low, while NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte has urged alliance members to increase oil-refining capacity amid escalating Russian hybrid threats.

Widening the net: The bloc is also seeking closer energy ties with neighboring non-EU countries that could help offset a U.S. diesel cutoff. That includes members of the Energy Community, a group of countries aspiring to join the EU and working to integrate their energy markets with the bloc — if falteringly .

Help from friends: "The solution for European energy security does not begin and end at the EU borders, it includes both neighbors and candidates like Moldova — the highest-performing Contracting Party of the Energy Community," Moldovan Energy Minister Dorin Junghietu told Ben.

Trump doubles down: The EU's Oil Coordination Group also meets today to assess what a U.S. ban on diesel exports could mean for Europe. Reminder: After the White House denied reports it was preparing a 90-day ban, Trump said Sunday he was still considering one "very seriously." Oil companies and industry groups are opposed, warning it could disrupt supplies and push prices higher.

Politics at the pump: Brussels sees a potential Trump move to ban diesel exports as driven by domestic politics ahead of November's midterms, a Commission official said.

The bottom line: Brussels is scrambling to stop this winter turning into another energy nightmare. Trump's diesel threat, low gas stocks, wars and Russian hybrid attacks are stacking the odds against it.

BIG AND BREAKING

CAVING ON CARS: The European Commission ignored its own advice to maintain a bloc-wide combustion engine ban and instead bowed to automakers and powerful national capitals to weaken the rules, according to an internal briefing document obtained by POLITICO. Jordyn Dahl has the full story .

AIR BASE PLOT: U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio told Fox News overnight that a "foreign actor" was clearly behind the suspected terror incident near a British air base on the weekend and that "there's a lot more news that will come out on this."

U.K. authorities earlier released on bail the five young men arrested Sunday but they're continuing to investigate the alleged plot, including whether it was state-backed, Sky News reports .

DEPORTATION DRIVE: Greece is spearheading a group of five EU countries pushing to send migrants who have been denied the right to stay in the EU to countries such as Rwanda from as early as next year, Nektaria Stamouli reports.

DIG DEEP: Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos will open a gathering of the Ukraine Donor Platform in Brussels today with an appeal to EU partners to provide more funding. "We need to shoulder the financing challenge ahead together," she told Playbook. "The European Union will be doing its part. But we need sufficiently ambitious commitments from everyone."

PULLED BACK TO EUROPE: A new POLITICO Poll shows that most British voters want their government to build a closer relationship with the EU — and even Nigel Farage’s supporters agree . But Andy Burnham’s Cabinet is far from united on the subject at Labour’s annual party conference, Jon Stone reports from Liverpool .

LIGHTS OUT FOR EPSO?

THE EU WEIGHS AXING EPSO: The European Commission is considering big changes to its civil service exam board amid a budget squeeze and criticism that the body is no longer fit for purpose — including possibly scrapping it, two EU officials told Playbook.

EPSO, created in 2002, is the gateway for EU civil servants, designed to pick the best and brightest from thousands of applicants. But it’s under growing scrutiny amid high-profile failures and the fact that the EU has fewer jobs to offer due to pressure on its long-term budget.

One scenario is simply to “get rid of EPSO,” said an EU official who’s involved in the thinking about reforms, granted anonymity to speak about the plans. The last open hiring round — which drew a record 174,922 applicants — proved “completely unmanageable,” the official said, adding that “the cost of administering this sort of mass exam is out of proportion to what we get out of it.”

The current model is “reaching its limits,” a second EU official said, lamenting that hiring currently takes between two and three years. “You will see quite far-reaching ideas on how the system could be changed.” A spokesperson for the European Commission did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

The plans follow a string of high-profile failures, including one last year that forced nearly 10,000 aspiring EU civil servants to retake an exam after a technical blunder voided their results.

In EPSO’s defense: Cristiano Sebastiani, who represents the Renouveau et Démocratie EU staff union, said the exam board isn’t delivering on its aim to boost hiring from underrepresented geographies and among younger applicants — but it should evolve, rather than be abandoned. “There is a role where it provides expertise to different services for their recruitment. But abolishing it entirely would be the wrong message to EU citizens.”

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya and Ian asked you to tell us about your experiences applying for EU jobs. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

EU countries last week reached a deal on using €6.6 billion in EU cash to aid Ukraine. That money will come from the European Peace Facility — but what is that? It’s a fund that’s not part of the EU budget and allows member countries to be partly reimbursed for military equipment they provide to Ukraine. The fund’s initial focus was to provide funding for military operations in mainly African countries, but that was before Russia invaded Ukraine.

RIGHT TO STAY

SHOULD I STAY OR SHOULD I GO? The European Commission's plan to help people stay in rural areas is taking shape — yet it's unlikely to bring fresh funding where it is wanted as governments fight over regional spending in the EU's next long-term budget, Zoya Sheftalovich reports.

The budget must give regions the capacity to build their own futures, said Kata Tüttő, president of the Committee of the Regions. "We cannot talk about people's freedom to stay while designing an EU budget that risks concentrating both decisions and investment in fewer hands and fewer places."

The plan: Expected in early 2027, the "Right to Stay" strategy will target gaps in jobs, housing and essential services that push people out of rural areas — but it's not expected to come with its own dedicated cash pot. Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto will host residents and regional representatives at the Berlaymont today to discuss obstacles to local prosperity.

Meanwhile ... EU governments are haggling over the bloc's next budget, with Germany leading a faction pushing to cut hundreds of billions from the total amount while southern and eastern countries are trying to protect EU support for farmers and poorer regions.

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6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

THE MÉLENCHON PLAN: French far-left presidential candidate Jean-Luc Mélenchon is betting that first-time voters will warm to his blunt style and radical social agenda and propel him into a runoff against Marine Le Pen .

Meanwhile, on the far right: National Rally President Jordan Bardella has "categorically denied" accusations by French investigative outlet Mediapart that he shared antisemitic remarks in private conversations as a teenage activist, Victor Goury-Laffont reports .

STANDING UP FOR THE ICC: European lawmakers are urging the Commission to block companies and banks from complying with U.S. sanctions against the International Criminal Court , Giovanna Faggionato writes.

NO COUNTRY FOR OLD WOMEN: Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez is under mounting pressure to deliver housing reform after the eviction of a wheelchair-bound pensioner sparked intense protests. Maricarmen Abascal's lawyer said she will be allowed to return to her home in Madrid, the BBC reports .

UKRAINE REGAINS GROUND: Ukraine's army pushed back Russian forces in a key part of the eastern front and captured more than 250 prisoners, Veronika Melkozerova reports from Kyiv .

But but but ... Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy posted on X last night that Russia is mobilizing more forces, with North Korea preparing to send another 10,000 troops.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals. High of 29C.

EXCLUSIVE — GREEN RACE HEATS UP: Flemish MEP Sarah Matthieu will officially file her candidacy to be Greens co-chair today, pitching herself as the candidate to put the group into full campaign mode ahead of the 2029 EU election. “In the run-up to the elections, we need to be out there: listening to firefighters, nurses, workers, industry leaders and innovative start-ups,” she told Max Giera, adding that this summer’s sprawling wildfires were a “wake-up call that our governments simply aren’t protecting us against the next extreme heat or flood.”

SPOTTED ... at the launch of BLOOM Association’s report on overfishing at Théâtre Varia, with a somewhat harrowing documentary screening, along with a string quartet and Champagne: BLOOM Association’s founder Claire Novian; MEPs David Cormand and Jean-Marc Germain; French MP Jean-Louis Roumegas; Thomas Klinkert, attaché at Luxembourg’s Ministry of Finance; European Commission’s Anne Coudeyre, Diane de Rouvre and Jules Danto; EBCD Director Despina Symons; Eduard Antics, project officer at CINEA; POLITICO’s Sebastian Starcevic.

NEW LOOK: Caffè Italiano, a favorite haunt for European Parliament officials looking for a hit of espresso or a bite of cornetti, reopened recently with a facelift, Playbook’s Sebastian Starcevic writes. The 14-year-old joint on Rue d’Arlon now resembles a luxe, albeit slightly generic, hotel bar. But the coffee’s still hot — not to mention cheaper than other bubble spots — and the place was still packed at 11 a.m.

COVER-UP: Brussels’ iconic Manneken Pis will be helped into his costume for the next few weeks — a robe donated by the Order of Saint Gabriel Benelux (named after the patron saint of diplomats). The dressing will begin at noon, at the intersection of Rue de l’Etuve and Rue du Chêne.

SKIP THE SANDWICH: Head to Salle Jacques Huisman at the Théâtre National this lunchtime for a discussion with author, poet and LGBTQ+ activist Joëlle Sambi on her book “Maison Chaos.”

JAZZ ON A BUDGET: The Toni Mora Trio plays a free show tonight at Playbook author Gabriel Gavin’s favorite Brussels jazz bar, The Music Village, on Rue des Pierres. There’s no charge on the door, although they ask you to buy at least one drink — making it a cheap cultural night out.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz and his ministers were in talks late into the night to settle a dispute over the government’s reforms to long-term care .

Paris: Centrist Edouard Philippe is stuck in third place in the presidential race, according to a new poll — and nothing he’s trying seems to be cutting through with voters.

London: Andy Burnham is expected to set out his 10-year plan for reviving Britain in his address to Labour’s annual party conference in Liverpool.

Washington: Donald Trump unveiled plans for a \$15 billion steel plant in Iowa — but voters aren’t feeling the economic growth he’s touting.

Ottawa: A top adviser to Mark Carney took up a seat in the Senate, marking a return to partisan appointments in Canada’s upper house.

Canberra: The Reserve Bank of Australia was expected to hike interest rates overnight in response to rising inflation, putting Labor under political pressure .

AGENDA

- Informal meeting of energy ministers in Dublin. Arrivals and doorsteps at 8:45 a.m. Press conference at 5:30 p.m. Watch live .
- Agriculture and Fisheries Council in Brussels. Press conference at 5:30 p.m.
- Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto hosts the implementation dialogue on the EU's Right to Stay policy.
- Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos delivers the opening speech at a meeting of the Ukraine Donor Platform in Brussels and receives Ukraine's Finance Minister Sergii Marchenko.
- Connecting Europe Days 2026 conference on mobility in Brussels. Commission President Ursula von der Leyen delivers an opening address at 2 p.m. Watch live .
- Political and Security Committee meets in Brussels at 10 a.m.
- EU High Representative Kaja Kallas is in Syria.
- Lithuania's Prime Minister Mindaugas Sinkevičius is in Brussels to meet Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis, Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius, NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte and European Parliament President Roberta Metsola. Lithuania's Finance Minister Taurimas Valys is also in town.
- Inauguration of the David Maria Sassoli Building at the European Parliament, with statements by Metsola and von der Leyen at 2:50 p.m. Watch live .
- Metsola will address the EU regions on the Cohesion Policy post 2027 at 5:45 p.m.

BIRTHDAYS

Former European Commissioner Helena Dalli; MEP Helène Fritzon; former Polish President Lech Wałęsa; Euractiv's Josh Posaner; former OECD Deputy Secretary-General Doug Frantz; European Council's Beatriz Navarro; the Commission's Daniele Calisti.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Amazon:** Lucas Pinos' Novoma began with a simple ambition: to make well-being accessible to everyone. Founded in Toulouse, France, Novoma set out to create food supplements built on transparency, trust, and scientific rigor. As demand grew, Amazon helped Novoma reach customers across Europe. "Amazon enabled us, as a small business, to reach new markets where we hadn't existed before, and drive strong growth in just one year," says Lucas. Novoma is one of thousands of European success stories selling on Amazon. In 2024, EU-based small businesses sold more than 1.3 billion products and generated over €34 billion in sales within the EU alone. Together, these entrepreneurs support an estimated 350,000 jobs across the EU, many in local and regional communities. By providing tools, logistics, and access to customers across borders, Amazon helps small businesses, like Novoma, grow beyond their local markets while staying rooted in their communities.

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